



Play Anything!

Lessons to familiarise yourselves with the most versatile media player

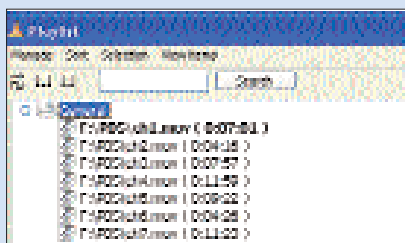
Jayesh Limaye

The VideoLAN or VLC media player is one of the most versatile players in the world, able to play virtually every major (and minor) format of audio and video. You don't need to install any codecs to be able to play a certain file format—VLC emulates them to play the files. The name isn't a misnomer either—you can even use it stream multimedia content over a LAN! VLC is highly portable and can be carried anywhere even on your thumb drive. You can find this open source media player on every *Digit* CD, and you'll find some handy VLC tips in *Digit*, December 2006.

Note: To execute any of the command-line commands here, go to **Start > Run > "cmd"** and navigate to your VLC installation directory at the command prompt.

Basic Stuff: Managing Playlists

Any media player needs a playlist to manage the order of media items to play. The VLC playlist can be accessed from **View > Playlist** or by pressing [Ctrl]+[P]. You can also bring up the



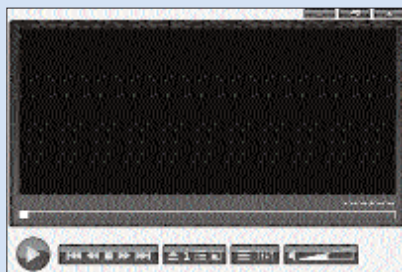
Using VLC's Playlist feature

playlist by simply clicking on the Playlist icon (the icon to the left of the Volume Control). Click on **Manage** to add files, directories or even URLs to the Playlist. You can also sort the Playlist by Title, Artist, or Album. Items can also be dragged-and-dropped to the Playlist, and you can drag an item in the Playlist to decide its order of playback. Common functions such as Shuffle, Repeat, and Search are also supported.

More Basic Stuff: Skins

VLC comes with a default simple look or "skin", but like most other media

players, VLC, too, supports skinning. Go to **Settings > Switch interface >**

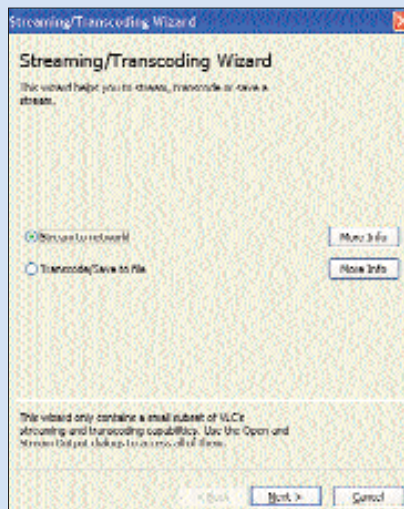


Skining VLC!

Skins 2 to view the alternative skinned VLC. You can also download and use one of the many skins from www.videolan.org/vlc/skins.php. Just place the skin in the Skins subfolder of the VLC installation (C:\Program Files\VideoLAN\VLC\Skins in most cases) and VLC will automatically detect the skin. Launch VLC and use the above method to load the skin. A little-known fact is that VLC also recognises and can use all the skins meant for Winamp2 and XMMS (.wsz files)!

The Streaming And Transcoding Wizard

While you can stream media over a LAN using the command-line interface, the easiest way to go about is by using the included Streaming and Transcoding Wizard. This Wizard is a step-by-step guide to streaming your media on a network or saving a



The Streaming/Transcoding Wizard

stream to your hard drive. To launch this wizard, go to **File > Wizard** or simply press [Ctrl] + [W]. Choose "Stream to network" if you wish to stream media on a network, or choose "Transcode/Save to file" if you wish to change a file's audio codec and/or video codec, its bitrate, and/or encapsulation method.

Now choose an input by selecting "Select a stream" (a stream can be a file, a network stream, a capture device or a hard drive), and clicking on **Choose**, or select an existing item in the playlist by choosing "Existing playlist item".

If you chose "Stream to network", you can specify a streaming method. The available methods include UDP Unicast, where you can stream to a single computer whose IP you need to specify. UDP Multicast allows you to stream to multiple computers by specifying multiple IP addresses, and HTTP lets you use the HTTP protocol to stream media. Check the box next to "SAP Announce" and enter the name for your stream if you wish to advertise it on the network using the UDP method. This option is unavailable if you chose the HTTP streaming method.

Setting Up A Video Streaming Server

A video file or a video capture device is all you need to start broadcasting videos over a network.

- 1 Start the Streaming and Transcoding wizard, and with the "Stream to Network" radio button checked, click **Next**.
- 2 You will now be prompted to choose an existing stream or choose a new one. Click on "Choose" to create a new stream.
- 3 Select a video file of your choice in the Open dialog box and click **OK**, then click **Next**.
- 4 Select the HTTP radio button, leave the Destination dialog box blank, and click **Next**.
- 5 Leave the Encapsulation format at the default (ASF) and click **Next**.
- 6 Enter "1" in the TTL dialog box and click **Finish**.
- 7 The Windows XP firewall will warn you about VLC—just choose **Unblock** in the dialog box.

Your video server is now up and streaming across the network. Now to